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EPISODE 308

Why Tehilim 67 is in the Shape of a Menorah

By Joseph Mosseri · Oct 28, 2026

Dedicated by Renee & Joseph Tawil in honor of SCA President, Ricky Novick. Thank you for all you do for our community!

So this is Mizmor Samekh-Zayin from Tehillim, Psalm number 67. Psalm 67 has 49 words, seven verses. That's not including the header Pasuk of "LaMnasseah BiNginot Mizmor Shir," which is four words that stand on their own. After those four words, we have 49 words within seven Pesukim. Those seven Pesukim are arranged in the shape, in the format of a Menorah, of a candelabrum, as you see over here.

According to many Hakhamim, this is an ancient tradition. This is the way David HaMelekh, when he wrote this Psalm, it's way it was envisioned to him by HaShem, and he would set this up on his shield when he would go out to battle, and he would concentrate on it, and that would help him win whatever battles he was fighting.

For us, our Hakhamim, beginning as early as 14th century Spain with Abudarham, talks about the importance of reciting this Mizmor, and a person who recites it properly in the format of the Menorah, it's as if he's in the Bet HaMikdash that morning, lighting the Menorah. And therefore it has become the custom to read this Mizmor prior to Barukh SheAmar, in the format, in the shape of the Menorah.

The problem is you'll see people flipping around their paper or their parchment or the Siddur in different ways so they could read it, but the proper way is the Menorah would be upright, and therefore you have to read it upright. Once you turn it, it's as if you're taking the Menorah and you're spilling out any sort of oil, you're extinguishing the lights. So it has to be held upright and has to be read upright, reading the words properly from it.

Now, what's the importance of it? According to many Hakhamim, whether they be The HIDA, or Ribbi Hayyim Palacci, or the Ben Ish Hai, or others, this is a form of protection for us. So not only are we reciting the Mizmor in the way that David HaMelekh envisioned it, not only is it like the Abudarham says, as if we're lighting the Menorah in the Bet HaMikdash, the same way it protected David HaMelekh when he went out, when you have the right concentration on it, and therefore it protects you as well.

But some people will say, "But we're not into superstitions. Is it really our tradition?" Not only is it our tradition, a person would be able to distinguish a Sephardic synagogue from an Ashkenazi

synagogue just by walking in. If he would see one of these on the wall, he would automatically know that this is a Sephardic synagogue. This is something that went throughout the Sephardic lands, whether you're talking about Syria, Eress Yisrael, Lebanon, Egypt, Iraq, Turkey, Greece, and so many other places. It made no difference. You saw this, you knew it was a Sephardic synagogue imbued with Sephardic tradition.

Like we said, this goes back to Spain, and it continued on and on. But not only that, in Syria it became an even greater thing. There was a book of Musar called Shebet Musar, written by Rabbi Eliyahu Kohen of Izmir. It was so beloved that Rabbi Yisshak HaKohen in Halab translated the book in 1925. It's called Shebet Musar on top, you'll see it in Arabic on the bottom it says what's translated as "The Staff of Ethics".

And in this book, in chapter 31, he talks about the importance of saying this Mizmor, and how they used to do it. They used to say it, this Mizmor by itself, in the format of the Menorah, and they would do it at sunrise. And a person that had an issue that day, and he was going out to take care of something, and he was looking for extra success, would say it in the format of the Menorah seven times at sunrise before going out.

So this is definitely something that was imbued within our communities. It's a beautiful custom. Don't let people tell you that it's a bunch of hocus-pocus and a bunch of nonsense. It's something very, very real, but you have to learn how to say it properly, how to concentrate on it, say it slowly and that's the reason it has HaShem's name so large on top, to make us focus that we're praying to HaShem, and in the merit of David HaMelekh, who said this Mizmor properly when HaShem showed it to him, and it helped him to win his battles, same way let us concentrate like David HaMelekh, that HaShem protects us and shows us the proper way as well.

Have a wonderful day.

(Disclaimer: This is a transcript of a video episode and may contain spelling or grammatical errors. As this transcript was generated from video, it may not fully capture the speaker's tone, emphasis, or intent — we recommend watching the video for the full experience and accuracy.)